

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 728

By Sexton

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Roy Foster Kramer of Vonore.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Roy Foster Kramer of Vonore; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kramer was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional, who will be remembered as a devout and humble man, a gifted orator, and a generous member of the community; and

WHEREAS, an iconic athletic coach and administrator for half a century, Roy Kramer was passionate about his work with his players, deeply understanding that it was his joy and privilege to have influenced generations of young people throughout his career; and

WHEREAS, he began his extensive coaching career as head football coach at Hudson, Dowagiac, Benton Harbor, and East Lansing schools, leading his teams to three Michigan high school state championships; and

WHEREAS, in 1968, Roy Kramer became the head football coach at Central Michigan University and earned numerous accolades, including a record of 83-32-2, an NCAA Division II National Championship win in 1974, and the NCAA Division II National Coach of the Year award in 1974; and

WHEREAS, while serving at Central Michigan University, he eventually led the University into NCAA Division I competition for all sports; and

WHEREAS, in 1978, Coach Kramer was named Athletic Director at Vanderbilt University; his transformation of Vanderbilt's athletic department was recognized nationally, and in 1990, he was selected as Commissioner of the Southeastern Conference (SEC); and

WHEREAS, during his thirteen years with the SEC, he pioneered conference expansion, conference football championship games, and postseason playoffs for Division I football; and

WHEREAS, the Men's and Women's SEC Athlete of the Year award is presented annually as the Roy F. Kramer Award, and in 2023, Coach Kramer was inducted into the College Football Hall of Fame; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kramer retired from the SEC in 2002, after which he and his wife of more than sixty years, Sara Jo, moved back home to the foothills of the Smoky Mountains; and

WHEREAS, Roy Kramer first met Sara Jo Emert while they were students at Maryville High School; Mr. Kramer was an athlete, Eagle Scout, and the class president, and Ms. Emert was a pianist, cheerleader, and debate champion; and

WHEREAS, Roy Kramer and Sara Jo Emert both attended Maryville College, and Mr. Kramer went on to serve as an officer in the United States Army during the Korean War, and then conferred a master's degree from the University of Michigan; and

WHEREAS, Mr. Kramer was preceded in death by his wife, Sara Jo Emert, and he leaves behind a host of family and friends; he was deeply devoted to his family and took great pride in caring for them, always endeavoring to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we hereby honor the memory of Roy Foster Kramer, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that we express sympathy and offer our condolences to the family and friends of Mr. Kramer.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.